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WORLD OF FOOTBALL



DRAMA DIALLED UP

Big teams falter in key matches as title battles enter a **decisive phase.**

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As the 2025-26 season enters its decisive phase, the race for Champions League qualification has intensified in the Premier League.

With the top two sides absent due to the League Cup final, none of the 'big boys' managed to capitalise.

Manchester United, rejuvenated under interim head coach Michael Carrick, missed the opportunity to solidify third place after being held to a 2-2 draw by Bournemouth. Its frustration was compounded by Harry Maguire's red card, which reduced the side to 10 men. United also took issue with Stuart Attwell's officiating, particularly a denied penalty after Amad Diallo was brought down in the box.

Liverpool's inconsistency under Arne Slot persisted with a 2-1 defeat to Brighton & Hove Albion. Danny Welbeck struck twice for the Seagulls, while Milos Kerkez netted the Merseyside club's lone goal. Chelsea, still reeling from its Champions League setback against Paris Saint-Germain, slumped to a 3-0 defeat to Everton, further denting its momentum.

Tottenham Hotspur endured a chastening 3-0 home loss to Nottingham Forest, deepening Igor Tudor's concerns amid a growing relegation threat. The only silver lining for the North London club was West Ham's 2-0 defeat to Aston Villa, which leaves the Hammers in the relegation zone. After gameweek 31, Arsenal leads the table with 70 points. Manchester City (61) sits second with a game in hand. Manchester United (55), Aston Villa (52) and Liverpool (49) occupy third to fifth, respectively, with Chelsea (48) in sixth. Tottenham (31) is 16th.

La Liga

Ronald Araujo proved decisive for Barcelona, with his goal securing a narrow win over Rayo Vallecano.